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Group 4
Project Proposal

**Introduction**:
Our project focuses on creating a database that not only organizes but also analyzes incidents of police violence in the US. The database we've created stores structured information about fatal encounters between civilians and law enforcement from 2013 to 2025. Each record will contain several attributes that describe the incident, including demographic information about the victim (age, race, gender, etc.); geographic details (such as state, city, county, and zip code); and specific event details such as the date of the incident, the agency involved, and/or whether the individual was allegedly armed, the reported threat level, whether the individual attempted to flee, the encounter type, the initial reason for the police interaction, and the official cause of death. By organizing these attributes into related tables, the database will allow users to run queries that identify trends across various related variables.

We chose this topic because police violence is a major social and public policy issue in the United States, and access to organized data can help support accountability efforts. Many advocacy groups and researchers rely on publicly available datasets to analyze patterns in police encounters. However, these datasets are often difficult to analyze without a structured database. Our project will make the information easier to explore by organizing the data in a way that allows users to answer questions that we've previously stated (e.g, where incidents occur most frequently). In conclusion, by structuring the data clearly, the database can help provide insights that support more humane and informed discussions about the police and our public safety.

**Target Audience**:
The primary target audience for this project is advocacy organizations and community groups working to reduce police violence in the United States. Organizations such as Black Lives Matter rely on accurate and accessible information that could support policy reform, as well as identify patterns, disparities, and timelines. By mapping incidents of police violence and taking note of important attributes, such as location, date of incident, weapons used, race, and age, our project will enhance the quality of the dataset for advocacy and accountability efforts.

**Potential entities/tables with potential attributes/columns:**

- Age
- Gender
- Race
- Date
- State, city, zip, county
- Agency responsible
- Allegedly armed
- Wapo armed
- Wapo threat level
- Wapo flee
- Encounter type
- Initial reason
- Cause of death
- Disposition official
- Call for service

**Entities/tables we will not include**:

- Victim image
- Street address
- Ori (not enough data)
- Officer charged (not enough data)
- New urls
- Wapo body camera (not enough data)
- Wapo ID (not enough data)
- Off-duty killing (not enough data)
- Geography (not enough data)
- Fe id (not enough data)
- Officer known past shootings (not enough data)
- Officer races (not enough data)
- Officer names (not enough data)

- Tract, longitude, latitude (we already have state & city)
- Urban-rural uspsai (not enough data)
- Urban-rural NCHS (not enough data)
- Hhincome medium census tract (not enough data)
- Pop total census tract (not enough data)
- Pop white census tract (not enough data)
- Pop black census tract (not enough data)
- Pop native american census tract (not enough data)
- Pop. Asian census tract (not enough data)
- Pop pacifier islander census tract (not enough data)
- Pop other multiple census tracts (not enough data)
- Pop Hispanic census tract
- Congressional district 113 (not enough data)
- Congressperson's last name (not enough data)
- Congressperson's first name (not enough data)
- Congressperson party (not enough data)
- Prosecutor head (not enough data)
- Prosecutor race (not enough data)
- Prosecutor gender (not enough data)
- Prosecutor party (not enough data)
- Prosecutor term (not enough data)
- Prosecutor in court (not enough data)
- Prosecutor special (not enough data)
- Independent investigation (not enough data)
- Prosecutor URL (not enough data)

**Unsure about:**

- Circumstances
- Signs of mental illness

**Sample data:**

We will consider what data will be the most important in terms of the questions we're trying to answer, as well as some that may be connected to the most important ones that we can't forget.

We won’t include the irrelevant ones. Luckily, our dataset isn’t too large, so we don’t have to worry about reducing it too much.

**10 Questions**:

1.) Where do the greatest number of incidents of police violence occur?
2.) What is the leading cause of death in incidents of police violence?
3.) What percentage of incidents result in charges against the police officer(s) involved?
4.) Which police departments are associated with the highest number of incidents?
5.) Which racial or ethnic group has the highest number of victims of police violence?
6.) What is the leading type of criminal activity reported?
7.) What is the average age of people killed by the police?
8.) Which age group has the highest number of police violence incidents?
9.) Who were the youngest and oldest victims recorded in the database?
10.) What were the most common causes of death?

**Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Considerations**:

Our database will likely not be inclusive of the full social, historical, and demographic diversity of its domain. The dataset only contains incidents of lethal incidents of police violence, and so non-lethal incidents are not represented. Police violence does not always result in civilian death, and so making conclusions about police violence with this dataset would be misleading, as it omits non-lethal incidents that make up a large number of police violence incidents overall. Additionally, the original dataset collected its data from multiple sources, one of which was official data sources from local and state government agencies. This leads to a lack of data, as most police agencies are not required to publicly report when their officers use lethal or non-lethal force against civilians. In 2024, only about 59% of police agencies voluntarily contributed to data collection programs (Koper et al., 2025). Not only would this result in a lack of data, but it also could skew data: if certain law enforcement agencies tend to report fatal incidents while others tend not to, then our database could suggest higher rates of police violence in certain areas where there might not actually be more police violence, but instead, there is a higher rate of reporting police violence.

Another cause of the lack of data is the mislabeling of the cause of death for victims of police encounters, where official causes of death are often incorrectly listed and so fail to indicate police involvement in the victim's death. This has been proven to occur most frequently in cases with Black and Hispanic victims (Oladipo, 2021). This misclassification results in these victims not being counted in datasets, such as ours, that detail killings from police violence. It should also be noted that the original database includes incidents of police violence in the United States from 2013 to January 10, 2025. Our database, therefore, cannot give a full historical or up-to-date picture of these incidents. Because of the above issues, we must recognize a lack of inclusivity in the original database and our database and work to better integrate inclusivity into our database's design.

**Data Privacy, Fair Use, Other Ethical Considerations:**

As our database is discussing mapping police violence, there is a serious concern about protecting user data. We have decided not to use any data that includes victims, particularly images that could reveal their identities. One entity that we may have a problem with is the "allegedly armed." With the term "allegedly," it is difficult to determine if the police officer was actually armed or not. In doing so, it could skew our interpretation of the data and our proposal. In terms of liabilities, it may be an issue when considering the zip code, county, city, and state, since it allows the data to be narrowed down. This is why we are excluding the street address so as to narrow it down. Since some of the data may be outdated or old, for example, as to whether the "alleged" arms were confirmed or not, there may potentially be more victims, which may cause us to acquire "closed" data. As we are keeping all of these in mind, we have taken out many columns that could allow data privacy breaches and are taking precautions against any legal issues.

## References

Koper, C. S., Baas, G., Taylor, B. G., Liu, W., & Sheridan-Johnson, J. (2025). Validating open-source data on fatal police shootings against self-reports from a national sample of police agencies. *Injury Epidemiology*, *12*(1), 68. https://doi.org/10.1186/s40621-025-00625-6

Oladipo, G. (2021, October 1). More than half of US police killings are mislabelled or not reported, study finds. *The Guardian*. https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2021/sep/30/police-killings-not-reported-mislabelled-study